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MIL-OSI NGOs: Governor Brown Signs Bill to End Destructive Swordfish Drift Gillnet Fishing off California

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Today, California Governor Jerry Brown signed into law a bill - Senate Bill (SB) 1017 (http://leginfo.legislature.ca.gov/faces/billNavClient.xhtml?bill_id=201720180SB1017) - that will clean up California's swordfish fishery. SB 1017 will phase out the use of large-mesh driftnet fishing for swordfish, establish a buyout program, and incentivize the use of cleaner fishing gear to reduce the incidental catch of marine wildlife.

"This hard-won victory was a long time coming. Finally we have found a way to phase out the use of these deadly and destructive nets without harming the commercial fishing industry in the process. I am grateful to Governor Brown for signing it into law," said Senator Allen. "I'm very pleased that we now can look forward to a time not far in the future when magnificent marine creatures will no longer be injured and killed by these nets. I am grateful to the lead supporters of the legislation, Pew Charitable Trusts, Oceana and Turtle Island Restoration Network, and hundreds of other groups, for their steadfast, effective advocacy of this measure," Allen added.

"We applaud the legislature and Governor Brown for their leadership in bringing this harmful and outdated fishing practice to an end," said Susan Murray, Deputy Vice President for Oceana. "This is literally an enormous net benefit for endangered whales, sea turtles and other marine life, as well as to responsible fishermen, coastal communities and seafood consumers. There is no longer room in our oceans for any fishery that throws away more than it keeps, especially in this case since we have sustainable alternatives to catch swordfish."

The swordfish drift gillnet fishery uses mile-long, nearly invisible mesh nets -nearly the length of the Golden Gate Bridge - that drift overnight in waters off California to capture swordfish. The nets often also entangle, injure and kill marine mammals like whales, dolphins and sea lions as well as endangered sea turtles, sharks and other important fish species. The nets kill more than 70 different species of ocean wildlife and, according to federal onboard observers, on average more than half of the total catch is tossed overboard already dead or dying. Despite 30 years of management measures aimed at reducing bycatch, the swordfish drift gillnet fishery remains one of the nation's dirtiest fisheries, which continues to kill more dolphins than all observed U.S. West Coast fisheries combined. Yet a new method called deep-set buoy gear has demonstrated profitability, higher market prices, and minimal bycatch.

The Governor's signature on SB 1017 will phase out the use of swordfish drift gillnets over a four-year period following establishment of a buyout program funded through public-private partnerships. Drift gillnet fishermen will be compensated $10,000 for their state drift gillnet permit and active fishermen will be compensated an additional $100,000 for surrendering their nets to the state for recycling and disposal.

SB 1017 passed the senate (33-0) in May and the assembly (78-0) in August with bi-partisan support with the

following co-authors: Senator Bob Wieckowski (D- Fremont) and Assemblymembers Richard Bloom (D- Santa Monica), William Brough (R-Dana Point), Wendy Carrillo (D- Los Angeles), David Chiu (D- San Francisco), Kansen Chu (D- San Jose), Laura Friedman (D-Glendale), Jesse Gabriel (D-San Fernando Valley), Todd Gloria (D-San Diego), Ash Kalra (D- San Jose), Marc Levine (D- Marin County), Brian Maienschein (R- San Diego), Kevin Mullin (D- South San Francisco), Al Muratsuchi (D- Torrance), Bill Quirk (D-Hayward), Mark Stone (D- Scotts Valley), and Marie Waldron (R- Escondido).

The bill also had broad support from conservation organizations, recreational fishermen, businesses, and the majority of California residents.

For more information about swordfish drift gillnets and gear alternatives visit www.oceana.org/stopthenets (http://www.oceana.org/stopthenets)

Oceana is the largest international advocacy organization dedicated solely to ocean conservation. Oceana is rebuilding abundant and biodiverse oceans by winning science-based policies in countries that control one third of the world's wild fish catch. With more than 200 victories that stop overfishing, habitat destruction, pollution and killing of threatened species like turtles and sharks, Oceana's campaigns are delivering results. A restored ocean means that one billion people can enjoy a healthy seafood meal, every day, forever. Together, we can save the oceans and help feed the world. Visit www.oceana.org (http://www.oceana.org/) to learn more.

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